



Don't Die Retired

30-DAY WORKBOOK

The Money Reset

A 30-day workbook for getting your finances clear after 50



50

Printable • Written for everyone over 50

Whether you've always been active or never got round to it

dontdieretired.com

WELCOME

The Money Reset

A 30-day workbook for getting your finances clear after 50. Retirement is a word for leaving a job, not a description of a person — and this 30-day workbook is written for anyone over 50 who wants to do more, not less, whether you've always been active or never got round to it.

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Print it

It's made for paper. Pin the tracker pages somewhere you'll see them every day.

Start small

Every plan has a beginner's route. Doing a little, often, beats doing a lot once.

Tick the box

A row of ticks is surprisingly powerful. It's how a habit becomes part of your life.

This workbook is general information and a way of organising your own thinking. It is not financial advice. Rules differ between the UK and the USA and change often. A regulated financial adviser (UK: FCA-authorised; US: a fiduciary adviser) can look at your own circumstances. Free guidance is available from MoneyHelper and Pension Wise (UK) and from the CFPB and the SSA (US). © Don't Die Retired. For personal use; please don't share or resell. Thank you for supporting an independent project.

Thirty days, one task a day, and at the end of it a complete picture of your money on a single page, a plan you understand, and a short list of the things you still need to check. No investment tips, no products, no clever schemes. Just clarity, which is the thing most people over fifty are actually short of.

Most of us do not have a money problem so much as a money fog. There is a pension from a job in the nineties that we have not looked at since. There are three current accounts, a savings account that pays almost nothing, a handful of subscriptions we forgot we had, and a vague sense that we ought to sit down and sort it all out one weekend. The weekend never comes, because 'sort it all out' is not a task. It is a mood.

This workbook turns the mood into thirty small tasks. Some take ten minutes. A few take an hour. None of them require you to understand markets, choose a fund or make a decision you cannot reverse. By Day 30 you will know what you have, what you owe, what comes in, what goes out, what you can expect from the state, where the gaps are, and which conversations you need to have next. That is the reset.

It is written for readers in the United Kingdom and the United States, because that is where most of you are. Where the two countries use different words for the same thing, both are given. Where they use different rules, both are described in general terms and you are pointed to the official place to check your own position. Rules change often and the differences are real, so treat every line about the state or about tax as a prompt to look it up, not as the last word.

■ How this works

- **Days 1 to 7: the one-page picture.** You build a net-worth table and a monthly cashflow table. Rough numbers are fine. Blank cells are fine. The point is to have one page instead of a drawer.
- **Days 8 to 14: where the money goes.** You track every pound or dollar for a fortnight, sort your spending into essential, flexible and joy, and audit the recurring costs that drip away unnoticed.
- **Days 15 to 21: what you already have.** You hunt down lost pensions and retirement accounts, get your official state forecast or statement, and draw a simple map of what you will draw from where.
- **Days 22 to 28: the big decisions and the protections.** Your home, scams, the money conversations with a partner and with adult children, wills and powers of attorney, and working part-time.
- **Days 29 to 30: the plan.** One page, a list of questions for an adviser, and a table of where to get free help.
- Each week ends with a **day-by-day plan** you tick off. Each section has **blank tables** to fill in. Print it, write in it, and keep it somewhere you will find it again next year.

i What this workbook is, and is not

It is a way of organising your own thinking and your own paperwork. It is not financial advice, and nothing in it is a recommendation to buy, sell, move or invest anything.

The rules on pensions, tax, benefits, Social Security and property differ between the UK and the US and change often. Check the official sources given at the end before acting on anything.

A regulated financial adviser (in the UK, one authorised by the Financial Conduct Authority; in the US, a fiduciary adviser who is required to act in your interest) can look at your own circumstances. Free, impartial guidance is available from MoneyHelper and Pension Wise in the UK, and from the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau and the Social Security Administration in the US.

■ Three ground rules before Day 1

- 1 No decisions for thirty days.** You are gathering, not acting. If a task makes you want to move money, cancel a policy or ring a broker, write the urge down in the margin and carry on. Almost nothing about money needs deciding today, and the things that do are usually the things someone else is pressing you to decide. That pressure is a warning sign, not a reason.
- 2 Rough is better than blank.** If you do not know a figure, estimate it and mark it with a question mark. A table with twelve estimates and three question marks is a picture. A table with nothing in it because you were waiting for the statements is not.
- 3 Nobody is marking this.** Whatever you find, whether it is more than you thought or less, it is information. The most common feeling on Day 7 is relief, simply because the fog has lifted. The second most common is mild annoyance at a subscription. Both are fine.

i Worksheet 1: my starting point

Today's date:

What I most want to know by Day 30:

What I have been avoiding:

What I am worried I will find:

Who I will do this alongside (partner, friend, nobody, all fine):

.....

The hour of the day I will give to it:

01 Days 1 to 7: The one-page picture

Two tables. The first is a snapshot: everything you own and everything you owe, on one day. The second is a flow: what comes in and what goes out in a typical month. Together they are the whole of personal finance, and most people have never seen theirs written down.

■ Net worth: what you own minus what you owe

Net worth is a plain phrase for a plain idea: add up the value of what you have, subtract what you owe, and the difference is where you stand. It does not tell you whether you are doing well or badly. It tells you where you are, which is the thing you need before any plan can be made. Fill in the table below over the first three days. Use the most recent statement, an online balance, or an honest guess with a question mark.

A few notes on the rows. Your home goes in at what you think it would sell for today, not what you paid. Pensions and retirement accounts go in at their current value, which is on the annual statement or the provider's website; if you cannot find one, put a question mark and it becomes a Week 3 task. Cars, furniture and possessions can go in at a token figure or not at all. Money you are owed by a family member goes in only if you genuinely expect it back.

What I own (assets)	Value (£ or \$)	Where the figure came from	Confident? (Y / ?)
Home (what it would sell for today)			
Other property			
Current / checking accounts			
Savings accounts and cash ISAs (UK) / savings and CDs (US)			
Premium Bonds, other government savings			
Workplace pension 1 (UK) / 401(k) or 403(b) 1 (US)			
Workplace pension 2 / retirement account 2			
Personal pension or SIPP (UK) / IRA (US)			
Defined benefit ('final salary') pension: yearly income promised			
Stocks and shares ISA (UK) / brokerage account (US)			

What I own (assets)	Value (£ or \$)	Where the figure came from	Confident? (Y / ?)
Other investments			
Life insurance with a cash value			
Business or share of a business			
Money owed to me			
Total assets			

What I owe (liabilities)	Balance (£ or \$)	Interest rate	Monthly payment
Mortgage			
Other secured loans (including equity release or reverse mortgage)			
Credit cards (each one)			
Personal loans, car finance			
Overdraft			
Money owed to family or friends			
Tax owed (Self Assessment, IRS)			
Anything else			
Total liabilities			
Net worth (assets minus liabilities)			



If the number is smaller than you hoped

Two things are worth saying. First, a net-worth figure that includes a paid-off or nearly paid-off home is a very different thing from the same figure held entirely in debt; the rows matter as much as the total. Second, this is Day 3 of 30. You have not yet found the lost pension, cancelled the forgotten subscription, or checked what the state will pay. Write the number down, date it, and move on. You will come back to it on Day 29.

■ Cashflow: what comes in and goes out each month

The second table is about flow rather than stock. Take a typical month, not your best one. Income after tax is what actually lands in the account. For spending, use last month's bank and card statements; you will get much more precise in Week 2, so a rough split now is enough. If you are a couple, do one table for the household or one each, whichever matches how you actually run things.

Money in (per month, after tax)	Me	Partner	Household
Salary or wages			
Self-employed or freelance income			
State Pension (UK) / Social Security (US)			
Workplace or private pension income / retirement account withdrawals			
Rental income			
Interest and dividends actually paid out			
Benefits, credits, other			
Total in			

Money out (per month)	Amount	Essential / Flexible / Joy	Note
Mortgage or rent			
Council tax (UK) / property tax (US)			
Energy, water			
Home, car, health and other insurance			
Food and household			
Transport: car, fuel, fares			
Phone, broadband, TV			
Debt repayments (cards, loans)			
Health, dental, prescriptions, glasses			
Subscriptions and memberships			
Eating out, hobbies, days out			

Money out (per month)	Amount	Essential / Flexible / Joy	Note
Gifts, family, charity			
Holidays (yearly total divided by 12)			
Irregular: repairs, car service, vet (yearly total divided by 12)			
Total out			
In minus out			

■ Essential, flexible, joy

You will have noticed the third column. Every line of spending goes into one of three boxes, and the sorting is the most useful ten minutes in this workbook. It replaces the idea of 'good' and 'bad' spending, which makes people miserable, with a question of what each pound is for.

Category	What it means	Examples	How to treat it
Essential	You cannot stop it without real harm or breaking a legal obligation.	Mortgage or rent, council or property tax, energy, basic food, insurance you need, medicines, debt minimums.	Cover it first, from the most reliable income. Shop around, but do not cut.
Flexible	You need something like it, but the amount and the supplier are your choice.	Phone contract, broadband package, the car you run, the supermarket you use, most subscriptions.	This is where audits pay off. Most 'savings' come from here without anyone noticing a difference.
Joy	It makes life better and that is the whole reason for it.	Holidays, grandchildren, the club, meals with friends, the hobby, the garden.	Protect it deliberately. A budget with no joy in it fails by March. Trim flexible before you trim joy.

Go back through the cashflow table and write E, F or J beside each line. Then add up the three totals. Most people find the joy total is smaller than they feared and the flexible total is larger than they realised. That is the whole argument of Week 2 in two numbers.

■ Week 1 plan: Days 1 to 7

Day 1

Fill in Worksheet 1. Gather what you can find in twenty minutes: last bank statement, last pension statement, mortgage balance, card balances. Do not go looking for anything that is not to hand.

☐

Day 2

Assets table: home, accounts, savings. Estimate anything you cannot find and mark it with a question mark.

☐

Day 3

Assets table: pensions, retirement accounts, investments. Write down the name of every provider you can remember, including ones with no figure yet. Total the assets.

☐

Day 4

Liabilities table: every debt, its rate and its monthly payment. Total it. Work out net worth and date it.

☐

Day 5

Cashflow: money in. Use last month's statements. After tax only.

☐

Day 6

Cashflow: money out, roughly, from last month's statements. Divide yearly costs by twelve.

☐

Day 7

Mark every spending line E, F or J. Add up the three totals. Read the whole page once, then close the book.

☐

02 Days 8 to 14: Where the money goes

Last week's spending figures were estimates from a statement. This week you find out what really happens, by writing down every purchase for fourteen days, and you audit the costs that recur whether you notice them or not. It is dull for about three days and then it becomes oddly satisfying.

■ The fortnight of tracking

The rule is simple: every time money leaves you, you write it down that day. Cash, card, contactless, direct debit, standing order, a transfer to a grandchild. A notebook in your pocket, the notes app on your phone, or the table below. The tracking runs through Week 2 and into Week 3, because a full fortnight catches the weekly shop twice and most of the monthly bills once.

- **Write the category as you go**, E, F or J, while you still remember why you bought it. Deciding a week later is guesswork.
- **Do not change your behaviour yet.** The point is to see the pattern, and if you spend less because you are watching, the picture is false. Spend as you normally would and write it all down.
- **Couples: both track**, on separate pages, then compare on Day 21. Not to judge; to see the whole household.
- **Round to the nearest pound or dollar.** Precision to the penny is what puts people off.

Date	What	Amount	E / F / J	How paid	Would I buy it again?

Date	What	Amount	E / F / J	How paid	Would I buy it again?

Print this page as many times as you need. Fourteen rows is one quiet day for some households and one morning for others.

■ The recurring costs audit

Recurring costs are the quiet leak. Each one was reasonable when you set it up. Together, years later, they can add up to a surprising monthly sum, paid by direct debit to companies whose names you half-recognise. This audit takes one sitting with your bank and card statements for the last twelve months. List every regular payment, however small. Then, for each one, answer the question in the last column honestly.

Payment (to whom)	Amount and frequency	What it is for	Last used or needed	E / F / J	Keep / Cut / Switch / Check

The four verdicts mean what they say. **Keep:** it earns its place. **Cut:** you had forgotten it existed, or it no longer does anything for you. **Switch:** you need it but could get the same thing for less, or the contract has quietly rolled onto a worse rate. **Check:** you are not sure what it is, which happens more than anyone admits, and a phone call will tell you.

■ Cutting costs without cutting the life out of things

A reset is not an austerity programme. The aim is to spend on purpose. In practice, most of the money people over fifty recover comes from a handful of places, and none of them involve giving up the things they enjoy.

- **Contracts that rolled over.** Broadband, phone, TV, insurance and energy contracts often move to a higher rate when the initial deal ends. A call to ask 'what is your best price for an existing customer?' before you switch costs nothing and frequently works.
- **Duplicates.** Two streaming services you watch one of. Insurance cover you also have through a bank account or a membership. Breakdown cover on both the car policy and a separate contract.
- **The small standing orders.** Charities you no longer feel connected to, memberships you stopped attending, a magazine you skim. Cancel with a clear conscience; you can always come back.
- **Interest on debt.** If the liabilities table shows a credit card carrying a balance at a high rate, that is usually the single most expensive line in your whole finances, and paying it down beats almost any other use of spare money. This is general information and the arithmetic is yours to check, but it is rarely wrong.
- **Joy stays.** If the audit makes you want to cancel the thing you love most because it is the biggest number, stop. Look at the flexible column first. The point of all this is to afford the joy column comfortably, not to remove it.

Worksheet 2: the Week 2 numbers

Recurring costs I found, in total per month: £/\$.....

Cut (per month): £/\$.....

Switched or renegotiated (per month): £/\$.....

Still to check:

The one I was most surprised by:

My 'joy' spending, protected on purpose: £/\$..... per month

■ Week 2 plan: Days 8 to 14

Day 8	Start the tracking log. Every purchase, today and every day until Day 21. Category as you go.	☐ _____
Day 9	Print or download twelve months of statements for every current account and card. Highlight every payment that repeats.	☐ _____
Day 10	Fill in the recurring costs audit from the highlights. Do not decide anything yet; just list.	☐ _____
Day 11	Go down the audit and write Keep, Cut, Switch or Check beside each line. Add up the Cut column.	☐ _____
Day 12	Cancel the Cuts. Most can be done online or by one phone call. Note the confirmation.	☐ _____
Day 13	Make the Check calls: 'What is this payment for?' and the Switch calls: 'What is your best price for an existing customer?'	☐ _____
Day 14	Fill in Worksheet 2. Look at the tracking log so far and note the first pattern you can see. Keep tracking.	☐ _____

03 Days 15 to 21: What you already have

The most cheerful week of the thirty. This is the one where people find things: a pension from a job they had forgotten, a retirement account from an employer that no longer exists, a state forecast that is better than they assumed. Not always; but often enough that the hunt is worth an afternoon.

■ Finding lost pensions (UK)

If you have worked for several employers since the 1980s, there is a reasonable chance that at least one of them enrolled you in a pension you have lost track of. Schemes change name, get merged, move to new administrators, and the letters go to an address you left two moves ago. The money is still yours. Finding it is a matter of patience rather than expertise.

- **Start with the list from Day 3:** every employer you can remember, with rough dates. Old payslips, P60s, CVs and LinkedIn are all useful for jogging memory.
- **Use the government's Pension Tracing Service** at gov.uk/find-pension-contact-details. It is free, and it gives you contact details for a workplace or personal pension scheme from the employer's or provider's name. It does not tell you whether you have money in it or how much; that is the next call.
- **Then write to the scheme** with your name, date of birth, National Insurance number, the employer and the dates. Ask whether you have benefits with them, what the current value or promised income is, and what the options are. Keep copies.
- **Be wary of anyone who offers to find your pensions for you**, especially if they contact you first or want to move the money once found. The tracing itself is free. The section on scams in Week 4 explains why this matters.
- **Do not transfer, consolidate or take anything yet.** Some older pensions carry valuable guarantees; some charge exit penalties; some are worth leaving exactly where they are. Finding is Week 3. Deciding is for later, with regulated advice if the sums are significant.

■ Finding retirement accounts and checking your record (US)

The American equivalent is the 401(k) or 403(b) left behind at a former employer, or an IRA opened years ago and never revisited. The same principle applies: it is still your money, the plan administrator has a duty to hold it or account for it, and a few letters will usually find it.

- **List every employer** where you think you had a plan, with dates. Old W-2 forms show whether you contributed to a retirement plan in a given year.
- **Contact the former employer's HR or benefits department first.** If the company has been sold or has closed, the plan will typically have been taken over by another administrator or terminated with balances paid out or transferred; the Department of Labor's website (dol.gov) has guidance on tracing plans and abandoned-plan records.

- **Check state unclaimed property.** Small balances are sometimes turned over to the state where you lived. Each state runs an official unclaimed property search; use the state's own site rather than a commercial one.
- **Get your Social Security Statement** by creating a free 'my Social Security' account at ssa.gov/myaccount. It shows your recorded earnings history year by year and an estimate of your future benefit. Check the earnings history carefully: a missing year is worth correcting, and the statement tells you how.
- **Do not roll over or cash out anything yet.** Cashing out early can trigger tax and penalties, and rolling over is a decision to make with the whole picture in front of you, not one account at a time.

■ The State Pension and Social Security, at a general level

The state provides a foundation in both countries: the State Pension in the UK, Social Security retirement benefits in the US. Both are earned by a record of contributions over your working life, both start from an age set by law that depends on when you were born, and in both countries the amount you get depends on your own record. The ages, the amounts and the rules change, and this workbook deliberately does not state figures. Your own forecast or statement is the only number that matters, it is free, and getting it is this week's most important task.

	UK: State Pension	US: Social Security retirement benefit
What it is	A regular payment from the government once you reach State Pension age, based on your National Insurance record.	A monthly benefit from the Social Security Administration based on your earnings record, claimable from a minimum age with a 'full retirement age' set by birth year.
How much you get	Depends on your number of qualifying years of National Insurance. Your forecast shows your current estimate and whether you can improve it.	Depends on your lifetime earnings and the age at which you claim. Claiming earlier reduces the monthly amount; claiming later increases it, up to a limit.
Where to check your own position	gov.uk/check-state-pension (your forecast) and gov.uk/state-pension-age (your age)	ssa.gov/myaccount (your statement and estimates) and ssa.gov/benefits/retirement (rules on age and claiming)
Things worth asking about	Gaps in your record, whether voluntary contributions could fill them and whether doing so is worthwhile, deferring, and how it interacts with any other income.	Errors in your earnings history, spousal and survivor benefits, how working while claiming affects payments, and how claiming age changes the amount.
Free help	MoneyHelper (moneyhelper.org.uk); Pension Wise, part of MoneyHelper, for guidance on defined contribution pension options	Social Security Administration (ssa.gov , or by phone or in person at a local office); Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (consumerfinance.gov)

Check your own forecast at

UK: gov.uk/check-state-pension for your forecast; gov.uk/state-pension-age for the age you can claim. You will need a Government Gateway login, which you can set up on the day.

US: ssa.gov/myaccount for your Social Security Statement and benefit estimates.

Print the result and file it with this workbook. Write the date on it; you will want to compare it next year.

■ What you will draw from where

By now you have a list of every pot: the state, workplace pensions or plans, personal pensions or IRAs, savings, perhaps a property, perhaps a part-time income. The next table is the simplest form of a retirement plan there is: for each source, when it can start, whether it is guaranteed or depends on markets, and what it might roughly provide. The last column is deliberately vague, because you are not going to project returns; you are going to note what the provider's own statement says, or a question mark.

Source	Earliest it can start (check)	Guaranteed for life, or a pot that can run out?	Rough yearly income, per the provider's statement, or ?	Notes / questions for an adviser
State Pension / Social Security		Guaranteed		
Defined benefit ('final salary') pension		Guaranteed		
Workplace pension / 401(k) or 403(b)		Pot		
Personal pension, SIPP / IRA		Pot		
Savings and ISAs / savings and brokerage		Pot		
Rental income or property				
Part-time work		While it lasts		
Partner's sources (if planning jointly)				

Two ideas fall out of this table on their own. One is that the guaranteed rows are the ones that will pay your essential column whatever happens, so it is worth knowing whether they cover it. The other is that the 'pot' rows can be drawn faster or slower, and in the UK how you draw them has tax consequences, which is exactly the sort of thing Pension Wise and a regulated adviser exist to talk through. You do not need to solve it this week. You need to see it.

■ Week 3 plan: Days 15 to 21

Day 15	Write the full list of past employers with dates. Check old payslips, P60s or W-2s, CVs.	☐ _____
Day 16	UK: use the Pension Tracing Service for each employer or provider you cannot find. US: contact former employers' benefits departments and run your state's unclaimed property search.	☐ _____
Day 17	Write or email each scheme or plan found, asking for a current statement and your options. Log who you wrote to and when.	☐ _____
Day 18	Get your State Pension forecast and age (UK) or your Social Security Statement (US). Print it. Note any gaps or errors.	☐ _____
Day 19	For every existing pension or account, find the most recent statement or log in. Update the Day 3 assets table with real figures.	☐ _____
Day 20	Fill in the 'what you will draw from where' table. Question marks are allowed.	☐ _____
Day 21	End of tracking. Add up the fortnight by category and compare with the Week 1 estimates. Couples: compare pages.	☐ _____

04 Days 22 to 28: The big decisions and the protections

None of the topics this week can be settled in a day, and this workbook does not try. The task is to understand each one well enough to know whether it applies to you, what the risks are, and who you would need to talk to. That is more than most people manage, and it is the difference between choosing and being sold to.

■ Your home: staying, downsizing, or releasing equity

For many people over fifty the house is the biggest number in the assets table by a distance, and the question of what to do with it hangs over every other plan. There are three broad options, and each is right for somebody. What follows is a neutral description of each, with its risks. It is not a recommendation.

Option	What it means	What it can give you	What to weigh carefully
Stay put	Keep the home, perhaps adapt it over time.	Continuity, community, no moving costs, the option of the other two later.	Running costs, maintenance, stairs and access in the years ahead, and whether the home is holding money you may need.
Downsize	Sell and buy somewhere smaller or cheaper, keeping the difference.	A lump sum you own outright, lower bills, often a more suitable home.	Selling and buying costs, stamp duty or transfer taxes, the emotional cost, and whether the smaller home really is cheaper once service charges and fees are counted. Rushed sales rarely fetch the best price.
Equity release (UK) / reverse mortgage (US)	Borrow against the home, usually repaid from its sale when you die or move into long-term care, while continuing to live there.	Money now without moving; some products allow a lump sum, others a drawdown facility.	Interest compounds over the years, so the debt can grow substantially and the amount left for you or your family shrinks. It can affect means-tested benefits. Early repayment can carry charges. It is a regulated product in both countries, with specific safeguards, and specialist advice is required before you can proceed.

On equity release and reverse mortgages specifically: in the UK, the Equity Release Council (equityreleasecouncil.com) is the industry body whose members sign up to a set of consumer standards; its website explains those standards and the questions to ask, and equity release advice is regulated by the FCA. In the US, the Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (consumerfinance.gov) publishes plain-language guides to reverse mortgages, including the costs, the responsibilities that stay with you (taxes, insurance, upkeep) and what happens to a spouse or heirs. Read the official guide from the relevant body before you speak to any provider, and speak to a regulated adviser who does not sell the product before you speak to one who does.

Worksheet 3: my home

Rough value today: £/\$..... Mortgage left: £/\$.....

Yearly running cost (tax, energy, insurance, upkeep): £/\$.....

Would it suit me in ten years as it is? (stairs, garden, distance from people):

.....

If I moved, where and why:

Am I considering equity release or a reverse mortgage? If so, what for:

.....

Who I need to talk to before deciding anything:

■ **Scams aimed at people over fifty**

People in their fifties and sixties are targeted because they have pensions, savings and property, and because the pension rules in both countries allow money to be moved in ways that a fraudster can exploit. The Financial Conduct Authority's ScamSmart campaign (fca.org.uk/scamsmart) is the UK's official guide to spotting investment and pension scams; the Federal Trade Commission (ftc.gov) and the CFPB do the same job in the US. Their advice comes down to a small number of warning signs and a small number of habits.

Warning sign	Why it matters	What to do instead
They contacted you first	Genuine pension and investment firms do not cold-call, text or message you out of the blue about your pension. Unsolicited contact is the single most reliable warning sign.	Hang up, delete, do not click. If curious, find the firm yourself through the official register and contact it through the details given there.
Pressure and deadlines	'This offer closes Friday' exists to stop you thinking and checking. Real opportunities survive a week's delay.	Say you never decide on the day. Anyone who objects has told you what you need to know.
Guaranteed or unusually high returns	Nobody can guarantee investment returns. Promises well above what a savings account pays are the bait.	Ask how the return is generated and who regulates the firm. Check the answer independently.
Free pension review, or help unlocking your pension early	Both are classic openings for moving your pension into something unsuitable or fraudulent, often with tax consequences you are not told about.	Free, impartial guidance exists from MoneyHelper and Pension Wise (UK) and the SSA and CFPB (US). Use those instead.
A sense of exclusivity or secrecy	'Don't tell your family' or 'this is only for a few people' is designed to isolate you from the people who would spot the problem.	Tell someone. The scam dies in daylight.

Warning sign	Why it matters	What to do instead
Unusual payment methods	Gift cards, cryptocurrency, transfers to a 'safe account', or couriers collecting cards are not how legitimate financial businesses take money.	Stop. Your bank will never ask you to move money to keep it safe.

- ☐ Before dealing with any financial firm, check it on the official register: the FCA's Financial Services Register in the UK (register.fca.org.uk); in the US, FINRA BrokerCheck (brokercheck.finra.org) for brokers and the SEC's adviser search (adviserinfo.sec.gov) for investment advisers.
- ☐ Use the contact details on the register, not those on the email, letter or website that approached you. Cloned firms copy real names and registration numbers.
- ☐ Never give remote access to your computer or phone to someone who called you.
- ☐ Agree with your partner or a trusted friend that neither of you moves a large sum without telling the other first.
- ☐ If you think you have been scammed, contact your bank immediately, then report it: Action Fraud in England, Wales and Northern Ireland, Police Scotland in Scotland; the FTC at reportfraud.ftc.gov in the US. Do not be embarrassed. It is common, and speed matters.

■ Talking money with a partner

Couples who have been together for decades can still have never had the whole money conversation. One person does the bills, the other does not ask, and each assumes the other has a plan. The Week 1 tables make the conversation easier, because they replace feelings with a page. Here is a way to run it that tends not to end in an argument.

The partner conversation

Pick a time that is not bedtime and not the moment a bill arrives. A walk works well; so does a Sunday morning with coffee.

Start with the picture, not the problem. 'I have written down everything we own and owe and what comes in and goes out. Can I show you?' Go through the page together. Let them correct it.

Then each say one thing you want the money to do in the next ten years. One thing. Not a list.

Then each say one worry. Just name it. Do not solve it yet.

Agree two things only: what you will each do before you next talk, and when you will next talk. Write both down.

Separately, make sure you each know: where the paperwork is, the passwords or how to get them, which accounts are in whose name, and what would happen to the household income if one of you died or needed care. That is a practical conversation, not a morbid one, and it is one of the kindest things you can do for each other.

■ Talking money with adult children

This one goes both ways. Your children may want to know your plans and be afraid to ask; you may want to help them and be unsure how much you can afford to; or they may be helping you, quietly, and nobody has said so. The aim is not to hand over your finances but to make sure the people who would have to step in one day are not starting from nothing.

- **Tell them the shape, not the numbers, unless you want to.** 'We are fine, the house is paid for, our pensions cover the basics, and the paperwork is in the blue folder' is enough for most families.
- **Say where things are.** The will, the powers of attorney, the list of accounts and providers, the name of any adviser. A single page in a known place saves months of misery later.
- **If you are giving money to children or grandchildren,** do it from the surplus in your cashflow table, not from the guaranteed rows or the emergency fund, and know the tax rules in your country on gifts before you do it. In the UK, gifts can have inheritance tax implications depending on timing and amount; in the US there are annual gift-tax exclusions and reporting rules. Both change; check gov.uk or irs.gov, or ask an adviser.
- **If a child is struggling and you are tempted to rescue them,** run the numbers on the Week 1 page first. Helping is good. Helping in a way that leaves you needing help in ten years is not, and your children would not want it.
- **If they are helping you,** thank them and put it on the page. Hidden help becomes resentment; acknowledged help becomes family.

■ Wills and powers of attorney

These are the two documents that stop a difficult time becoming a catastrophic one, and a striking number of people over fifty have neither, or have a will made before children, a divorce or a house move that no longer says what they mean. This is general information; the law differs between the UK's nations and between US states, and a solicitor or attorney, or an official guide, is the place to check.

Document	UK	US
Will	Sets out who gets what, who administers the estate (executors) and, if relevant, guardians for children. Without one, the intestacy rules decide, which may not be what you want, especially for unmarried partners and stepchildren. Guidance at gov.uk/make-will and from Citizens Advice.	Same purpose; rules are set by each state, and dying without one ('intestate') means state law decides. Some assets pass by beneficiary designation (retirement accounts, life insurance) regardless of the will, so those designations need checking too.

Document	UK	US
Power of attorney	A lasting power of attorney (LPA) lets people you choose make decisions if you lose the capacity to make them yourself. There are two kinds: property and financial affairs, and health and welfare. In England and Wales they are registered with the Office of the Public Guardian; Scotland and Northern Ireland have their own versions. Guidance at gov.uk/power-of-attorney .	A durable power of attorney for finances and a healthcare power of attorney (or healthcare proxy) do the same jobs; 'durable' means it stays in force if you lose capacity. Forms and rules vary by state; a state bar association, a legal aid office or an elder-law attorney can point you to the right ones.
Why now, not later	An LPA can only be made while you still have capacity. Made in good health it sits in a drawer, possibly for decades, costing nothing more. Made too late, it cannot be made at all, and the alternative is a slow court process for your family.	Exactly the same logic. Also review beneficiary designations on every account after any marriage, divorce or death in the family; they override the will.
Review when	Marriage (which can revoke an earlier will in England and Wales), divorce, a birth, a death, a house move, or every five years or so.	Same triggers, plus moving to another state.

■ Working part-time in retirement

Many people over fifty find that some paid work, a day or two a week, is good for the money, good for the head, and good for the calendar. It also changes the plan: every year of part-time income is a year you draw less from the pots, and the guaranteed rows can start later. A few things to know at a general level.

- **Earnings and the state.** In the UK, you can work and receive the State Pension at the same time; earnings are taxed in the usual way and you stop paying National Insurance once you reach State Pension age. In the US, if you claim Social Security before your full retirement age and keep working, earnings above a limit reduce your benefit temporarily; after full retirement age they do not. The details and the limits are on ssa.gov, and it is worth reading them before you claim.
- **Earnings and your pension pots.** In the UK, once you have started taking money flexibly from a defined contribution pension, the amount you can pay in with tax relief drops sharply. If you might want to keep contributing, find out before you draw. Pension Wise will explain this for free.
- **Self-employment** has its own rules on registering and paying tax in both countries; our Second Act workbook covers the practical side in more depth.
- **Put it on the page.** Add part-time income to the cashflow table and the 'draw from where' table as its own row, with a note of how long you expect it to last. Plan as if it will end sooner than you hope; then any extra year is a bonus.

■ Week 4 plan: Days 22 to 28

Day 22	Read the home options table and fill in Worksheet 3. If equity release or a reverse mortgage is on your mind, read the Equity Release Council or CFPB guide first.	☐ _____
Day 23	Read the scams table. Check any firm you currently deal with on the official register. Agree the 'no large moves without telling each other' rule with someone.	☐ _____
Day 24	Have the partner conversation, using the script. If you are single, have the 'where things are' conversation with whoever would step in.	☐ _____
Day 25	Talk to your adult children, if you have them, about the shape of things and where the paperwork lives. Write the one-page 'where things are' sheet.	☐ _____
Day 26	Find your will, or note that you do not have one. Check it still says what you mean. Check beneficiary nominations on every pension or account.	☐ _____
Day 27	Find your power of attorney documents, or read the official guide (gov.uk/power-of-attorney , or your state's resources) and note what you need to do.	☐ _____
Day 28	If part-time work is part of your plan, add it to the cashflow and 'draw from where' tables. Read the official page on how earnings affect your state benefit.	☐ _____

05 Days 29 to 30: The plan

Two days to turn four weeks of gathering into one page you can act on, and a list of questions for the conversation with an adviser, if you have one. Then you put the workbook somewhere safe and get on with your life, which was the point.

■ The one-page plan

Go back to Day 4 and Day 7. Update the net-worth figure with everything you found in Week 3 and everything you cut in Week 2. Then fill in the table below. It should fit on one side and be readable by someone who has never seen your finances before, because one day someone may need to.

My money on one page	Day 30 answer
Net worth today (from the updated Week 1 table)	
Monthly money in, after tax	
Monthly money out: essential / flexible / joy	
Monthly surplus or shortfall	
Recurring costs cut or switched this month (per month)	
Pensions or accounts found or updated in Week 3	
State Pension / Social Security: my forecast, and the age it starts (from the official source)	
Guaranteed income vs essential spending: does the first cover the second?	
The 'draw from where' order, as I currently understand it	
Decisions I am NOT making yet, and what I need to know first	
Will: exists / needs updating / needs making	
Power of attorney: exists / needs making	
The three things I will do in the next thirty days	
Date I will repeat the reset	

■ Questions to ask an adviser

An hour with a regulated adviser is most useful when you arrive with the one-page plan and a list. In the UK, look for a firm authorised by the FCA and check it on the Financial Services Register; MoneyHelper explains the kinds of adviser and how they charge. In the US, ask any adviser whether they act as a fiduciary at all times for you, and check them on BrokerCheck or the SEC's adviser search. Take this list, tick what you ask, and write the answers on the page.

- ☐ Are you authorised or registered, and with whom? Can I check that myself, and where?
- ☐ Do you act as a fiduciary (US) or give independent, whole-of-market advice (UK)? If not, what are the limits of what you can recommend?
- ☐ How are you paid: a fee I pay you, a percentage of what I hold, or commission from products? What would this conversation and any follow-up cost me, in pounds or dollars?
- ☐ Looking at my one-page plan, what is the biggest risk you can see?
- ☐ Does my guaranteed income cover my essential spending? If not, what are my options for closing the gap?
- ☐ Which of my pension or retirement pots should I draw from first, and why? What are the tax consequences of each order?
- ☐ Do any of my older pensions carry guarantees or penalties I should know about before moving anything?
- ☐ Should I fill any gaps in my National Insurance or Social Security record, and is it worth the cost?
- ☐ When should I claim my State Pension or Social Security, given my health, my other income and my plans to keep working?
- ☐ If I am considering downsizing or equity release, what would you want me to understand first, and are you paid differently depending on what I choose?
- ☐ What should I do about the debt on my liabilities table before anything else?
- ☐ What happens to my income and my partner's if one of us dies first? Are the nominations and beneficiary designations right?
- ☐ Is there anything on this page you would tell a friend to change today?
- ☐ What do you need from me, and when should we speak again?

■ Where to get free help

What you need	UK	US
General money guidance, impartial and free	MoneyHelper: moneyhelper.org.uk (government-backed; budgeting, pensions, debt, scams)	Consumer Financial Protection Bureau: consumerfinance.gov (guides on retirement, reverse mortgages, debt, scams)

What you need	UK	US
Pension guidance	Pension Wise (part of MoneyHelper): free appointments on defined contribution pension options; Pension Tracing Service: gov.uk/find-pension-contact-details	Social Security Administration: ssa.gov and 'my Social Security' at ssa.gov/myaccount; Department of Labor on workplace plans: dol.gov
Your state pension or benefit	gov.uk/check-state-pension and gov.uk/state-pension-age	ssa.gov/benefits/retirement
Checking a firm or adviser is genuine	FCA Financial Services Register: register.fca.org.uk; FCA ScamSmart: fca.org.uk/scamsmart	FINRA BrokerCheck: brokercheck.finra.org; SEC adviser search: adviserinfo.sec.gov
Reporting a scam	Action Fraud (England, Wales, NI): actionfraud.police.uk; Police Scotland (Scotland)	Federal Trade Commission: reportfraud.ftc.gov
Debt help	Citizens Advice: citizensadvice.org.uk; StepChange: stepchange.org (free debt charity)	CFPB guidance on debt collection and credit counselling at consumerfinance.gov; look for a non-profit credit counselling agency
Wills and powers of attorney	gov.uk/make-will; gov.uk/power-of-attorney; Citizens Advice	Your state bar association's referral service; local legal aid for those on low incomes; the CFPB's guides for financial caregivers
Equity release / reverse mortgage	Equity Release Council: equityreleasecouncil.com; MoneyHelper	CFPB reverse mortgage guides: consumerfinance.gov
Older people's advice	Age UK: ageuk.org.uk (money, benefits, care)	AARP: aarp.org; National Council on Aging: ncoa.org

■ Week 5 plan: Days 29 to 30

Day 29

Update net worth with everything found and cut. Fill in the one-page plan. Compare with Worksheet 1: did you find out what you wanted to know?



Day 30

Write the three things you will do in the next thirty days. Tick the adviser questions you want to ask, and book the conversation if you are having one. Put the workbook, the 'where things are' sheet and the forecast together in one place, and tell one person where it is.



■ What happens next

You have done something most people put off for years: looked at the whole of it, on one page, without flinching. The fog has gone, and what is left is a small number of clear questions and a plan you understand. That is not a small thing. It is the thing.

- **Repeat the reset once a year.** Same tables, same order, one weekend. Write the date in the diary now. Most of it will take a quarter of the time the second year, because the drawer is already organised.
- **Keep the tracking habit in a lighter form.** A monthly glance at the cashflow table, or a quarterly recurring-costs check, catches the drift before it becomes a leak.
- **Take the decisions you parked, one at a time, with the right help.** The home, the draw-down order, the will and the power of attorney each deserve their own quiet hour and, where the sums are large, a regulated adviser who is paid by you and not by the product.
- **Say no to anyone who contacts you first.** That one habit protects everything else on the page.

■ Keep going with us

The newsletter. Once a week at dontdieretired.com we send a short, practical email for people over fifty who intend to keep going: something to try, evidence explained without the jargon, and no hype. You can leave any time.

Our other workbooks. Money is one leg of the stool. Second Act is for those who want to earn something from a skill or an idea; The 30-Day Restart and Strong at 60 are for the body; Sharp is for the mind; Reconnect is for the people around you. All are at dontdieretired.com.



Before you close the book

Write next year's reset date in the diary.

Tell one person where the paperwork is.

Make the first phone call on your 'three things' list this week.



You do not need to be good with money. You need to know what you have, what you owe, what comes in, what goes out, and who to ask. Everything else is detail.

The Money Reset

This workbook is general information and a way of organising your own thinking. It is not financial advice. Rules on pensions, tax, benefits, Social Security and property differ between the UK and the US and change often; check the official sources listed above, and speak to a regulated financial adviser (FCA-authorised in the UK; a fiduciary adviser in the US) about your own circumstances before acting. Free guidance is available from MoneyHelper and Pension Wise in the UK, and from the CFPB and the Social Security Administration in the US.

KEEP GOING

This is the start, not the finish.

Every day at dontdieretired.com we publish a true story of someone who began something late — and the plan behind it. Join the free Sunday email and you'll get one story, one idea and one thing to try each week.

MORE FROM THE SHELF

The 30-Day Restart

Ten minutes a day, chair to stairs

Strong at 60

12-week beginner strength plan

Eat Strong

Four-week kitchen planner

Sharp

8 weeks to a learning habit

Second Act

90-day venture workbook

Reconnect

Six weeks to a fuller social life



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